

Rubidium

37
Rb

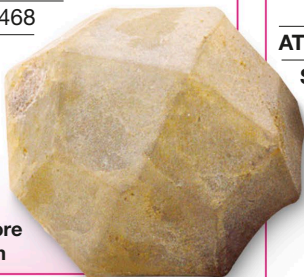
This metal is very rare compared to other alkali metals. Rubidium is named after the Latin word for “red” as it produces a deep-red flame when it burns. It is used only in a few high-tech applications, such as night-vision goggles.

ATOMIC MASS 85.468

STATE Solid

DISCOVERY

1861 (Gustav Kirchhoff and Robert Bunsen)



Leucite, an ore of rubidium

Caesium

55
Cs

The most reactive metal found on Earth, caesium explodes violently on contact with air. It is used in atomic clocks, the most accurate timepieces yet invented.

ATOMIC MASS

132.905

STATE Solid

DISCOVERY 1860

(Gustav Kirchhoff and Robert Bunsen)

Laboratory sample of pure caesium in an airless vial



Francium

87
Fr

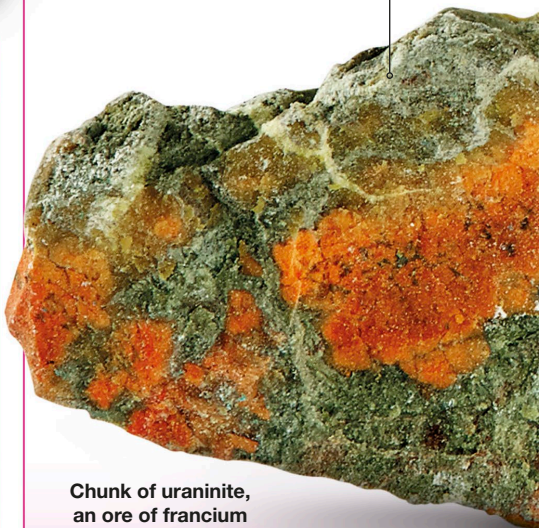
The atoms of this radioactive element exist only for a few minutes before breaking up. As a result, francium is one of the rarest elements. This metal was one of the last elements discovered in nature because of its rarity. It was named after the country in which it was first found, France.

ATOMIC MASS (223)

STATE Solid

DISCOVERY 1939 (Marguerite Perey)

As the uranium in this ore breaks down, it releases actinium atoms, which in turn break down to release francium atoms.



Chunk of uraninite, an ore of francium